



Audio Production

Getting better audio

Mastering the art of audio production

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In the world of audio production, the landscape is constantly evolving. With the advent of Artificial Intelligence (AI) and advanced digital tools, the boundaries of what is possible are being pushed further than ever before. For those who have mastered the basics of audio production, the next step is to delve into the more advanced techniques that can truly elevate your work. This article aims to guide you through some of these techniques, covering topics such as advanced mixing, mastering, plugins, layering, and automation. By applying these techniques, you can take your audio production skills to the next level and create professional-sounding projects.



Advanced Mixing Techniques

Mixing is an art form in itself. It's where

you blend all the individual tracks in a recording to create a soundscape that is pleasing to the ear. Mixing involves balancing the levels, panning, frequency, dynamics, and effects of each track to achieve a coherent and harmonious whole. However, mixing is not just about technical skills, but also about creativity and experimentation. Here are some advanced techniques that can help you spice up your mixes and make them stand out:

- **Side-chain Compression:** This is a popular technique in music production, especially in electronic music. It involves using the output of one track to control the compression on another. For example, you can have a kick drum cause a bass line to duck in volume every time it hits, creating a rhythmic pulsing effect that can make your mix sound more cohesive and energetic. To do this, you need to set up a compressor on the bass track and

use the kick track as the side-chain input. You can adjust the threshold, ratio, attack, and release settings to fine-tune the effect.

- **Mid/Side Processing:** This technique involves processing the middle and sides of a stereo track separately. The middle is the part of the signal that is identical in both the left and right channels, while the sides are the parts that are different. By processing them separately, you can manipulate the stereo width and depth of your mix. For example, you can use an equalizer to boost the high frequencies on the sides to make your mix sound wider, or you can use a compressor to reduce the dynamics on the middle to make your mix sound more focused. To do this, you need to use a plugin that can split the signal into mid and side components, such as FabFilter Pro-Q 3.



Mastering for Different Platforms

Mastering is the final step in the audio production process. It involves optimizing the overall sound to ensure it translates well on all playback systems. Mastering involves applying subtle adjustments to the volume, frequency, dynamics, and stereo image of your mix to make it sound polished and professional. However, different platforms have different standards for audio, so you need to be aware of them and master accordingly. Here are some of the most common platforms and their audio specifications:

- **Spotify:** Spotify is one of the most popular streaming services in the world, with over 300 million users. Spotify normalizes all audio to -14 LUFS (Loudness Units Full Scale) with a ceiling of -1 dBTP (decibels true peak). This means that Spotify will reduce the volume of any audio that exceeds these levels to avoid distortion and clipping. To optimize your music for Spotify, you should aim for these levels in mastering, or